ENGLISH SOUNDS & SOUND SYSTEMS · SOSE 2026

Sounds Sprint / Cheat Sheet

Choose **RP or GA**. Check sounds → stress → weak forms → accent consistency → connected speech.

Resit: Friday, 16 October 2026 · 10:00–12:00 · HGA 30 · Bring your student ID.

01 / The core distinctions

Phonetics = physical sounds. **Phonology** = sound system.

/phoneme/ = meaning-distinguishing category. **[phone]** = realization. **Allophones** = variants of one phoneme.

Minimal pair: one phoneme changes, meaning changes. *price–prize* yes; *bury–berry* no (homophones); *thin–than* no (two changes).

Count: child 4; aisle 2; psyche 4; sew 2; Chicago 6; sword RP 3 / GA 4. Diphthongs and affricates count once.

02 / Consonants: three features

Voicing + place + manner. /w/ = voiced labio-velar approximant.

Plosives: /p b t d k g/. Fricatives: /f v θ ð s z ʃ ʒ h/. Affricates: /tʃ dʒ/. Nasals: /m n ŋ/. Approximants: /r j w/ plus lateral /l/.

Bilabial /p b m/; labiodental /f v/; dental /θ ð/; alveolar /t d s z n l/; palato-alveolar /ʃ ʒ tʃ dʒ/; palatal /j/; velar /k g ŋ/; glottal /h/.

RP /r/ is a post-alveolar approximant [ɹ]; broad transcription uses /r/.

03 / Vowels: three coordinates

Height + backness + rounding. /iː/ close front unrounded; /uː/ close back rounded; /ə/ mid central unrounded; /æ/ near-open front unrounded.

RP short: /ɪ e æ ɒ ʊ ʌ ə/. Long: /iː ɑː ɔː uː ɜː/. Diphthongs: /eɪ aɪ ɔɪ aʊ əʊ ɪə eə ʊə/.

Schwa is unstressed in the RP model. A diphthong is one nucleus. HappY uses /i/, as in /ˈhæpi/.

04 / RP ↔ GA

Set / word	RP	GA (course)
car	/kɑː/	/kɑːr/
task	/tɑːsk/	/tæsk/
hot	/hɒt/	/hɑːt/
go	/gəʊ/	/goʊ/
bird	/bɜːd/	/bɝːd/ or /bɜːrd/

GA /t/ may tap [ɾ] (course ţ). GA *new* often /nuː/. Do not mix accent systems.

05 / Allophones & syllables

Aspiration: /p t k/ at stressed onset, except after /s/: pin [pʰɪn], spin [spɪn].

RP l: clear before vowel or /j/; dark [ɬ] before consonant or pause. Check word boundaries.

Syllable: onset + nucleus + coda. Rhyme = nucleus + coda. Nucleus can be a vowel or a syllabic consonant: [n̩ l̩].

streets /str–iː–ts/ = CCCVCC. tasks = CVCCC. eye = V. Adding consonants does not add syllables.

06 / Stress & compounds

Primary ˈ and secondary ˌ stress go **before** the syllable: /ˌfəʊtəˈgræfɪk/.

ˈimport (noun) vs imˈport (verb). ˈgreenhouse vs ˈgreen ˈhouse. ˈhotdog vs ˈhot ˈdog.

Double: ˈcheese ˈsandwich; ˈOxford ˈRoad.
Early: ˈOxford Street; ˈapple juice; ˈalmond cake.

English rhythm is described as stress-timed: a tendency, not equal clock intervals.

07 / Weak forms you need

a /ə/ · an /ən/ · and /ən(d)/ · at /ət/ · but /bət/ · can /kən/ · to /tə/ · of /əv/ · that /ðət/ · was /wəz/ · have /həv, əv/.

the: /ðə/ before a consonant sound; /ði/ before a vowel sound. for: RP /fə/, GA /fər/.

Strong forms: emphasis, contrast, citation, isolation; many prepositions in final position. Sentence-final pronouns are not automatically strong.

Content words usually carry stress. Function words usually reduce. Context decides.

08 / Endings follow sounds

Plural / possessive / 3rd-person -s:
/ɪz/ after /s z ʃ ʒ tʃ dʒ/;
otherwise /s/ after voiceless, /z/ after voiced sounds.

Past -ed:
/ɪd/ after /t d/;
otherwise /t/ after voiceless, /d/ after voiced sounds.

cats /s/, kids /z/, buses /ɪz/. looked /t/, turned /d/, wanted /ɪd/.

ng: singer /ŋ/; finger /ŋg/; longer and longest /ŋg/.

09 / Connected speech

Assimilation: a sound becomes more like its neighbour. good boy → [gʊb bɔɪ]: regressive place assimilation.

Elision: deletion. first day → [fɜːs deɪ] (RP); baked beans → [beɪk biːnz].

Linking r: four eggs /fɔːr egz/, there is /ðər ɪz/. A vowel must follow in RP.

Intrusive r: [r] without historical r, e.g. law and order. Not an instruction to insert r everywhere.

10 / The transcription checklist

1. State RP or GA.
2. Write sounds, not letters. Watch silent letters.
3. Mark word stress before the syllable.
4. Reduce unstressed function words.
5. Check linking r, assimilation and elision.
6. Read back and check accent consistency.

Traps: recipe /ˈresəpi/; debt /det/; salmon /ˈsæmən/; Reading /ˈredɪŋ/; loose /luːs/ vs lose /luːz/.

Friday: 16 October · 10–12 · HGA 30 · student ID. Both exam parts must be passed.

Independent revision aid · Based on the supplied course slides, outline, word keys and wrap-up/mock solutions. Traditional classroom RP/GA conventions; real pronunciation varies. Not an official exam key. Reviewed 14 October 2026.